

2, It is Necessary to Distinguish Between Political Efficiency and Social Efficiency

Another highly meaningful reflection for me is that I now recognize the so-called "political efficiency" (政治效率) genuinely does not equate to "**social efficiency**" (社会效率).

Here, the term "**social efficiency**" refers to the proportion of the **surplus of social production** (社会生产剩余) utilized for expanded reproduction, technological investment (*including investments in basic science, engineering, culture, arts, education, etc.*), the improvement of public services and welfare, the advancement of humanitarian causes, and the promotion of consumption.

In the context of our country, these two types of efficiency are constantly and deliberately conflated. For instance, our country's official propaganda declares that Western democratic nations are overwhelmingly inefficient, that their governments are always in a state of instability, and that they are paralyzed by internal polarization, making it difficult to take unified action. It then proceeds to claim that our political system is supremely efficient, having achieved brilliant developmental successes under "visionary, unified leadership."

Here, the "efficiency" touted in our country's political propaganda is, almost without exception, purely *political efficiency*.

However, over the past six months, I have clearly realized that the social development of humanity must be founded upon long-term evolution. Therefore, in determining the fundamental question of the rise and fall of nations, **social efficiency is the ultimate determinant—the absolute deciding factor** (胜负手).

The extent to which the **social surplus** (社会剩余) can be directed toward productive accumulation and technological investment directly dictates the speed at which a society can develop and progress, which in turn determines the degree of development and liberation every individual can attain.

Political efficiency, on the other hand, is a *neutral* concept. Although intellectually I certainly knew this in the past, I admittedly lacked an intuitive feeling for it. Yet, the events of the past six months delivered a massive shock to my core. Now that I clearly comprehend just how horrifying the crimes a government can commit—over such a prolonged period and across such a massive scope—can be, the "neutrality" of this term is utterly comprehensible to me.

When a government functions well and its decisions reflect the overall needs of society, high political efficiency is naturally exceedingly beneficial for social development, and **social efficiency** will consequentially rise.

But when the government's fundamental interest lies precisely in suppressing the demands of society and sabotaging any changes that might occur, then high political efficiency means that social production undergoes catastrophic destruction, and social wealth is annihilated much more thoroughly. In this scenario, let alone **social efficiency** not being high, deliberately driving it down to absolute zero over the long term is entirely achievable.

In fact, we can observe that except during developmental stages no later than **early slavery** states (早期的奴隶制)—where natural forces, namely disasters humanity could neither contain nor predict, or the critical scarcity of resources (*quite evident in pre-Columbian Mesoamerica*), could cause human society to stagnate in a certain period or even regress—nature ceased to be the primary obstacle.

Once humanity's capacity to transform nature leveled up significantly on the eve of the emergence of classical empires due to advancements in metal smelting (*marked, as discussed in the first part, by the expansions of Ancient Greece, the Chinese Zhou Dynasty, and the Indian Aryans*), regional natural disasters could no longer halt the progress of civilization itself, provided there was no global cataclysm.

To a large extent, this was also because the scope of civilization itself had expanded. For instance, when Aegean civilization was confined merely to the island of Crete, a single volcanic eruption was sufficient to inflict devastating consequences. But when the ancient Greeks established colonial city-states all across the Mediterranean coast (*saying "all across" is an exaggeration, of course*), natural disasters of the original scale were no longer sufficient to deal a fatal blow to the civilization.

Therefore, we can clearly see that since entering the era of classical states, there has essentially been only one fundamental cause for the stagnation or even regression of a civilization: **the emergence of a "cancer cell" (癌细胞) within the civilization.**

This takes the form of a massive, parasitic rentier class (食利阶层)—epitomized by a **bureaucratic system** that failed to conclude normally—that consumes virtually all of the **social surplus**, thereby driving the **social efficiency** of that civilization toward absolute zero.

We can (somewhat loosely) analogize this transformation to the growth of the human body itself.

When a person is very young, their internal immune system is highly immature; at this stage, the massive threats to human life are external injuries and pathogenic microorganisms. However, in today's era of advanced medicine, people no longer have to resign themselves to fate (听天由命) the moment they fall ill like the ancients did; the average life expectancy has more than doubled compared to two thousand years ago.

Consequently, in old age, people are forced to increasingly face diseases caused by the dysfunction of their own bodily systems—with cancer being the prime representative.

Could anyone claim that a cancer cell is a cell lacking vitality?

Obviously not. **Cancer cells do not lack vitality; they are *too* vibrant.** It is just that their vitality is an absolute catastrophe for the human body itself.

The numerous examples cited previously also demonstrate that in an anomalous **bureaucratic state**, the higher the political efficiency, the more impossible it becomes for **social efficiency** to be high, and the greater the price the entire society must pay.

Formally speaking, we can express this relationship mathematically: **[Total Surplus of Social Production] × [Social Efficiency] = [Total Volume of Effective Investment]**

This total volume of effective investment then directly determines the quality and quantity of a civilization's inventions and innovations.

Therefore, we can very easily answer a historical conundrum: why small nations are capable of achieving monumental feats, while many massive nations boasting immense populations and territories remain stagnant "colossuses with feet of clay" (泥足巨人).

If we observe Ancient Egypt and Ancient Greece during the final millennium BC, the total population in Egypt's Nile River Valley was clearly vastly larger than that of the regions encompassed by Ancient Greek civilization. However, the **social efficiency** of Egyptian society at that time was probably indistinguishable from zero. In stark contrast, Ancient Greek society demonstrated a remarkably high **social efficiency** rarely seen in the entire ancient world.

Consequently, in terms of absolute volume, the Greeks held a distinct advantage in productive accumulation and technological investment. This is precisely why the Ancient Greeks were able to create such breathtaking civilizational achievements.

As for the comparison between the European Christian states during the **Middle Ages** and a behemoth like China, the example is even more glaring. Although China possessed a colossal volume of total wealth and a massive **surplus of social production**, the amount that could be *effectively utilized* was practically nonexistent. Under these circumstances, fantasizing about achieving greater development than Europe was utterly impossible—not to mention that the imperial court fundamentally never welcomed such development to begin with!

Of course, there genuinely are historical cases where a state utilized overwhelmingly high political efficiency to coercively extract social wealth and channel it into effective investment—though such examples are pitifully scarce.

People can easily observe that such a phenomenon did indeed occur in China during the era of Emperor Wu of Han. This can be proven by the booming inventions and dramatic social progress in our country between the 1st century BC and the 1st century AD. *(During this extremely brief period, a trend of **feudalization** was generated from right within the classical empire. If one visits museums in Shaanxi and Henan to view the terracotta models of massive manors [大型庄园] from the Eastern Han Dynasty, one will gain a highly intuitive understanding of this).*

However, this was a reaction made by a **classical state** in response to powerful external stimuli. The fact is, after the Han Dynasty, such a historical phenomenon *never* reappeared in China. **All that the restoration-bureaucratic states did was drag down the hind legs of the entire nation!**

Therefore, we can say with certainty: brainwashing the commoners into believing that "political efficiency is everything" while completely ignoring or obscuring the concept of **social efficiency** is a quintessential hallmark of Chinese-style propaganda.

Naturally, we must also point out the inherent relationship between political efficiency and **social efficiency**.

A country with excessively low political efficiency cannot possibly have high **social efficiency**. This is because excessively low political efficiency inherently means the society is in a state of violent turmoil, where stable social relations do not even exist. Let alone using the **social surplus** to expand production and investment, simply maintaining basic survival production becomes a question. Naturally, **social efficiency** cannot be high.

Conversely, a country with excessively low **social efficiency** cannot maintain high political efficiency over the long term either. Excessively low **social efficiency** signifies the existence of a massively bloated **rentier class** (食利阶层) wielding political power within the society. Expecting these parasites to maintain highly efficient administration—especially to react swiftly when facing crises or changes—is pure delusion.

For anyone harboring even the slightest doubt about this fact, my advice is simply to come live in China for three years; I honestly see no need to offer any further rebuttal.

People often quote British Prime Minister Winston Churchill, saying that democracy is not necessarily the best system, but it is undoubtedly the least bad system.

Actually, in my view, when facing the military pressure of the Soviet Union at the dawn of the Cold War, Churchill clearly lost some of his nerve. He should have stated with absolute, unquestionable certainty: **Democracy is the best system humanity can currently observe and has ever realized.**

The profound significance of this system lies in the fact that, although it cannot enforce absolute, coercive administrative conformity (令行禁止) like certain despotic states, in the long run, it guarantees that **social efficiency** (社会效率) is maintained at a highly elevated level. This is because every individual's private property and the fruits of their labor are genuinely respected and protected, and the people possess greater freedom of development and choice.

Furthermore, we must point out that the so-called "political inefficiency" of democratic nations—epitomized by developed **capitalist societies** like the United States, Britain, and France—is nothing more than a delusional fantasy (意淫) residing in the minds of the Chinese people, a byproduct of the global geopolitical peace being maintained for far too long.

When the Japanese bombed Pearl Harbor, were they too banking their hopes on the illusion that the United States—the world's largest democratic nation (in terms of scale)—would struggle to rapidly respond to a total war (总体战争)?

Regardless of what the Japanese thought back then, they were clearly blown wide awake by the USS *Enterprise* (企业号航母) returning to the battlefield no matter how heavily bombed, the inexhaustible swarms of warships and aircraft, the endless supply of ammunition, and ultimately, two nuclear weapons! **Must other nations pay as catastrophic a price as Japan to finally realize this?**

As for whether **social efficiency** itself can be quantitatively used to measure the developmental level of a society, this remains an open question at present. Personally, I lean toward the hypothesis that—excluding the transitional phases between class societies—the **social efficiency** of each stage is invariably higher than the preceding one: from **slavery society** (奴隶制社会) to **feudal society** (封建社会), and then to modern **capitalist society** (资本主义社会).

However, I also recognize that an exact value for this **social efficiency** cannot possibly be precisely calculated, and thus far, there is no effective research methodology to do so. Therefore, I cannot draw a definitive conclusion, and can only wait to see if future scholars unearth better research tools.

While pondering the issue of these two types of efficiency, and integrating my previous views on the land issue—namely, that the fundamental requirement of modernization is the decline of land's status among the factors of production, yielding the position of the **primary factor of production** (首位生产要素) to capital—I increasingly feel that when examining a sociological problem, one must focus on grasping the **"fundamental variables"** (根本量) relevant to the issue, and absolutely avoid being blinded by secondary variables and relationships.

For example, the transition from feudalism to early modern and modern society demands that the paramount status of land in the socio-economic structure be dismantled and surrendered to capital. As long as this is happening—regardless of the methods used or which class leads it, despite variations in speed and cost—society will ultimately march toward a modern society; conversely, failing to do so means deviating from modernization.

The momentum of social progress is dictated by **social efficiency**. Therefore, whether it is despotic rule implemented by an exceptionally brilliant monarch like Emperor Wu of Han, or the diverse systems implemented by the numerous city-states of Ancient Greece, as long as high **social efficiency** is guaranteed within a certain period, massive leaps in social development are the inevitable result.

This mode of thinking—seeking the "key variables" (关键量) in a problem—bears a striking resemblance to certain mathematical theorems, such as **Gauss's Law** (高斯定理 / Gauss's Flux Theorem). We need only observe the **flux** (通量) of certain key variables passing through the entirety of a historical period. As for the convoluted complexities of how the social structure circulated within, there is no need to care too much about it initially.

I do not know whether such "key variables" exist universally in sociology. But based on my long experience of living in China, I can state with absolute certainty: **concealing the significance—or even the very existence—of "key variables," thereby misleading the people into focusing their attention entirely on secondary variables and relationships, is precisely the infallible magic trick (不二法门) the bureaucratic state (官僚国家) uses to deceive its people.**

2, 应当区分政治效率和社会效率

另一个对我来说比较有意义的反思是, 我现在认识到所谓政治效率的确不等于社会效率。在这里我说的“社会效率”这个词, 指的是社会生产剩余被用于扩大再生产, 进行技术投资 (包括对基础科学, 工程学, 文化, 艺术, 教育等等的投资), 完善公共服务和福利, 推进人道主义事业, 促进消费的比例。这两个效率在我国的语境中时常被故意混淆, 例如我国官方就宣称西方的民主国家是极其低效的, 政府总是处于不稳定的状态, 而且内部因为意见撕裂而难以采取统一步调。进而声称我国的政治体制是极为高效的, 在高瞻远瞩的统一领导下取得了辉煌的发展成绩。在这里, 我国的政治宣传中所强调的效率, 几乎清一色的都是政治效率。但是在过去半年的时间里, 我清楚地意识到人类的社会发展必须基于长期演变, 因此在决定国家兴衰这个根本问题上, 社会效率是具有决定性的, 成败的胜负手。社会生产剩余能有多大程度用于生产性积累和技术投资, 直接决定了这个社会能以多快的速度发展和进步, 进而决定了每个人能得到多大的发展和解放。而政治效率是一个中性词汇, 虽然在过去我从理智上当然也知道这一点, 但是的确是缺乏直观感受的, 然而过去六个月的事情给了我很大的震动。现在我清楚地了解到政府能够在多长的时间里多大的范围内犯下多么恐怖的罪行, 那么这个词的“中性性”就是可以被完全理解的了。对于运转良好的, 政府本身的决策能够反映社会总体需求时, 政治效率高对于社会发展当然是一件极有利的事情, 社会效率也会因此得到提升。但是当政府的利益压根就是压制这个社会的需求, 破坏可能产生的一切变化的话, 那么政治效率高就意味着社会生产得到了极大的破坏, 社会财富得到了更为充分的销毁, 社会效率不要说不高, 长期清零也不是做不到的。

其实我们可以观察到, 除了在不晚于早期奴隶制国家的发展阶段时自然力量, 也就是人类无法遏制和预测的灾害或者关键资源的匮乏 (这在前哥伦布时代的美索美洲比较明显) 会使得人类社会长期停滞在某一时期甚至退化以外。一旦人类在古典帝国产生的前夜因为金属冶炼的水平得到了提升, 改造自然的能力明显上了一个台阶之后 (标志就是第一部分所说的, 古希腊, 中国周朝, 以及印度雅利安人的扩张), 只要不是全球性的灾变, 区域性的自然灾害已经没办法在阻止文明本身的进步。这在很大程度上也是因为文明本身的范围扩大了, 例如当爱琴海文明还局限在克里特一个岛的时候, 那么一次火山喷发就足以造成毁灭性的影响。但是当古希腊人把殖民城邦建得遍及地中海沿岸 (这里的遍及当然是夸大的说法) 都是的时候, 那么原先规模的自然灾害就不足以对这个文明造成致命打击了。因此我们可以清晰

地看到，自从进入古典国家以来，文明的停滞甚至倒退本质原因无非只有一个，那就是文明内部产生了一种“癌细胞”，一个没有正常结束的官僚体制为代表的庞大的几乎消耗了全部社会剩余的食利阶层，使得这个文明的社会效率趋近于零。

可以（不太形象地）把这种变化比拟为人体本身的成长，在一个人很小的时候，体内的免疫系统是很不成熟的，此时对生命造成巨大威胁的是外部的伤害和致病性微生物。但是在医学发达的今天，人们已经不再像古人一样一旦得病就只能听天由命，人均寿命比两千年前涨了一倍不止。因此人们在老年就不得不更多面对自己身体功能失调所造成的疾病，这其中就以癌症为代表。难道一个人能说癌细胞是一种缺乏活力的细胞吗？显然不可以，癌细胞不是没有活力而是太有活力了，只不过它的活力对于人体本身而言就是一种灾难。

之前所举的那么多例子也表明，在一个非正常的官僚国家，政治效率越高，社会效率就越不可能高，整个社会要付出的代价就越大。从形式上看，社会生产剩余的总量乘以该社会的社会效率就等于该社会的有效投资的总量，这个总量又直接影响了发明创造的质和量。因此我们可以非常容易地回答一个问题，那就是为什么小国也能够成就大业，而许多人口和领土都极为庞大的大国却如同泥足巨人。如果我们观察公元最后一个千年的古埃及和古希腊，则埃及尼罗河流域的总人口虽然明显比古希腊文明所涵盖的地区更为庞大，但是当年的埃及社会所具有的社会效率恐怕跟零比也没有什么区别了，而古希腊社会则展现出了整个古代世界少有的高社会效率。因此从总量上看，希腊人在生产性积累和技术投资上明显占优势，因此古希腊人才能创造出令人惊叹的文明成果。至于中世纪时期欧洲基督教国家和中国这样的庞然大物相对比的例子则更为显著了，中国的财富总量虽然庞大，社会生产剩余虽然庞大，但是能有效利用的几乎没有，在这种情况下妄想取得比欧洲更大的发展是不可能的，更别说朝廷本来也不欢迎这样的发展。

当然确实也有以极高的政治效率去强制吸取社会财富并将其进行有效投资的案例，虽然这样的例子本身少到可怜。人们很容易看到汉武帝时期的中国确实出现了这样的现象，这一点可以被公元前一世纪和公元一世纪200年间我国蓬勃的发明创造和突飞猛进的社会进步（在极短的时间内就由古典帝国内部产生了封建化趋势，如果到陕西和河南的博物馆中去看一看东汉时期大型庄园的陶土模型就会有非常直观的感受）所证明。这属于古典国家在应对强力外部刺激时所做出的反应，事实是，在汉代以后中国再也没有出现这样的历史现象，复辟官僚国家所做的不过是拖整个民族的后腿罢了。因此我们可以说，让老百姓认为政治效率就是一切，而完全忽视或者不了解社会效率，就是一种典型的中国式宣传。当然，我们也应该指出政治效率和社会效率之间存在这样一种关系。政治效率过低的国家社会效率不可能高，这是因为过低的政治效率本身就意味着社会处于一种动荡状态，稳定的社会关系甚至都不存在，不要说把社会剩余用来扩大生产和投资，恐怕连维持生产都已经成为问题了，社会效率自然是高不了的。反过来说，社会效率过低的国家政治效率也无法长期维持高位，社会效率过低意味着社会内部存在一个非常大的拥有政治权力的食利阶层，指望这些人维持高效的行政特别是在应对变化时采取迅捷的反应简直是做梦，对这件事情有任何疑问的人我的建议是来中国生活三年即可，实在是看不到有任何反驳的必要。人们常常引用英国首相丘吉尔的话说，民主未必是最好的制度，但一定是最不坏的制度。

其实在我看来，丘吉尔在冷战初期面对苏联的军事压力时明显失掉了一些胆色，他应该以毫不怀疑的口吻说，现在民主制度就是人类所能看到的，已经实现的最好的制度。这种制度的意义在于它固然不能够像一些专制国家一样以强制的行政力量实现令行禁止，但是从长久来看它确保了社会效率能够维持到较高水平，因为每个人的私有财产也好，劳动成果也罢确实受到了尊重和保护，人民具有更多发展和选择的自由。我们更应该指出，以美国，英国，法国这样的发达资本主义国家为代表的民主国家所谓在政治上的低效不过是中国人脑中的“意淫”罢了，是全世界总体和平局面维持太久的结果。当年日本人轰炸珍珠港的时候，他们是否也寄希望于美国这个世界最大（从规模上说）的民主国家难以快速地应对一场总体战争呢？不管日本人当年怎么想，他们现在显然已经被无论怎么炸都能快速重回战场的企业号航母，数不尽的战舰飞机，打不完的弹药，以及两枚核武器给炸醒了。难道其他国家非得像日本一样付出这么大的代价才能意识到这一点吗？至于社会效率本身是否能够用来衡量社会发展水平这一点目前存疑，我个人倾向于不考虑阶级社会之间的过渡阶段，那么从奴隶制社会到封建社会，再到现代的资本主义社会，每一个的社会效率都要高于前一个。但是我又觉得这一社会效率的值毕竟不可能精确地得到，迄今为止也没有什么有效的研究方法，因此也不能给出什么论断，只能看看将来是否有人发掘更好的研究手段。

我在思考两种效率的问题的过程中，结合之前对于土地问题（即近现代化的根本要求在于土地在各生产要素中的地位下降，并将首位生产要素让给资本）的看法，越来越感觉当人们考量一个社会学问题的时候，应当注意去抓住与问题相关的“根本量”，而千万不要被一些次要的量和关系所迷惑。例如从封建主义到近现代社会的过渡要求土地在社会经济中占据的首要地位丧失并让位于资本，那么无论是用什么方式，由哪个阶级主导，虽然在速度和成本上会有差异，但是最终总会迈向近现代社会，反之则会背离现代化。社会进步的力度取决于社会效率，那么无论是像汉武帝这样才能卓著的君主实施专制统治，还是古希腊的诸多城邦国家所实施的不同种类的制度，只要能够保证一定时期内的高社会效率，社会发展取得长足进展都是必然的结果。这种找问题中的“关键量”的思维看起来很像数学中的一些定理（比如高斯定理），我们只观察通过整个历史时期的一些关键量的通量即可，至于其中经过了怎样复杂的社会结构流转，则在最初没必要关心太多。我不知道“关键量”在社会学中是否普遍存在，但是我以我在中国生活了这么久的经验可以很肯定地说，隐藏“关键量”的意义乃至存在，误导人们把注意力放到次要的量和关系上，的确是官僚国家欺骗百姓的不二法门。